CRITICAL CLASH

Tamil Nadu governor R.N. Ravi is accused of a "constitutional misadventure" following his latest run-in with the DMK government of M.K. Stalin over tainted minister V. Senthil Balaji. In his less than two-year stint, the guv has never been out of the news (and mostly for the wrong reasons). The major flashpoints:



- **Oct. 30, 2021:** Just a month after taking over, calls meeting of all Tamil Nadu varsity vice-chancellors (V-Cs). Then higher education minister **K. Ponmudi** complains he was not informed
- **Nov. 11:** Appoints R.M. Kathiresan as V-C of Annamalai University—the alma mater of many DMK/ AIADMK leaders—without consulting the state government, prompts latter to adopt legislation empowering itself to appoint V-Cs instead of the governor
- **Dec. 9:** Ravi pushes for the National Education Policy (NEP) at a convocation of the Bharathidasan University. DMK ministers declare they will not implement NEP in state
- **Feb. 1, 2022:** Returns **NEET Exemption Bill**, passed by the assembly on Sept. 13, 2021, to speaker. Assembly re-adopts bill, sends it back to governor on Feb. 8. Ravi puts it on hold for three months before forwarding it to the MHA on May 4 for President's assent



- **Jan. 4, 2023:** Slams the state's "regressive politics", says Tamizhagam is a more appropriate term for Tamil Nadu while felicitating organisers of the Kashi Tamil Sangamam at Raj Bhavan. DMK and rival AIADMK slam Ravi while state BJP springs to his defence
- **Oct. 28:** Asks why it took "over four days" for the state government to recommend a probe by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) into the Coimbatore car blast after the police had arrested the suspects. The state maintains it is a gas cylinder blast, Ravi calls it a terrorist attack
- **Aug. 25:** Guv claims the revered Tamil classic, *Thirukkural*, was being misused by those "who don't believe in God" at an unveiling of saint-poet Thiruvalluvar's statue in Delhi. DMK mouthpiece *Murasoli* slams him for trying to portray *Thirukkural* as the voice of Aryans
- **May 31:** State government accuses governor of keeping 21 bills passed by the assembly pending
- **Apr.19:** Faces black flag protests in Mayiladuthurai for delaying bills passed by legislature. Ravi alleges stones were thrown at the governor's convoy, which is rebutted by state police
- **Jan. 9:** Skips a paragraph with references to the Dravidian model of governance while delivering the Governor's address to the assembly. Stalin moves a resolution to retain only the approved speech copy given by the government even as Ravi walks out in a hurry. Later, DMK and allies boycott governor's 'At Home on Republic Day' function



- **Feb. 23:** Comments on Twitter about the murder of an army jawan in Krishnagiri after meeting state BJP chief **Annamalai** and a group of ex-servicemen. DMK comments that Raj Bhavan has been turned into a "coffee shop for useless people"
- **Mar. 9:** Returns the Tamil Nadu Prohibition of Online Gambling and Regulation of Online Games Bill, adopted by the assembly on Oct. 19, 2022. The state had passed the bill following a series of suicides by those stung by losses on these platforms



- **May 31:** Writes to CM about sacking minister **V. Senthil Balaji** following ED raids. Stalin refuses. He insists again, on June 15, when CM recommends that portfolios held by Balaji be reassigned. On June 30, Ravi orders Balaji's dismissal but within hours asks for the order to be put on hold
- **May 4:** Alleges in a media interview that the state government, among other things, allowed the two-finger test on minor children of Chidambaram Dikshithars. Outraged government and police attack comments, deny allegations
- **Apr. 6:** Tells civil service aspirants that withholding a bill by the governor means it is dead. Four days later, Stalin, in an unprecedented resolution, asks the Centre and President to fix a timeframe for governors to approve bills adopted by state assemblies. Ravi clears pending bills the same day

Madras High Court had, on October 31, 2022, ordered a fresh investigation into the case involving Balaji. In an order on May 16, the Supreme Court set that aside and cleared the way for the old probe to continue, giving the Tamil Nadu police a 60-day deadline to complete the process. In 2021, the Central Crime Branch (CCB) Job Racket Wing of the police had filed a charge against Balaji and 46 others for an alleged racket that involved taking cash in exchange for jobs in the state-run Metropolitan Transport Corporation during 2011-2015, when Balaji was transport minister in Jayalalithaa's AIADMK government. In July 2021, the ED filed related money-laundering charges.

The ED has been pursuing cases against top government functionaries in Delhi and West Bengal too, but it seems Stalin has strategised better than CMs Arvind Kejriwal and Mamata Banerjee in tackling the situation. By letting Megala, Balaji's wife, challenge procedural issues with the minister's arrest through a habeas corpus petition, the DMK has taken the fight to the ED. On July 4, the Madras High Court delivered a split verdict on the petition. While Justice J. Nisha Banu declared Balaji's arrest illegal and ordered that he be set at liberty, Justice D. Bharatha Chakravarthy differed with that view. Chief Justice S.V. Gangapurwala named C.V. Karthikeyan as the third judge to hear the case afresh from July 6, for a final decision on the matter. ■